

The Phone is **Losing You Patients** Every Single Day

A data-driven look at what dental receptionists are struggling with — and exactly how Sara AI closes the gap.

35%

Calls go unanswered

At the average UK dental practice daily

78%

Hang up at voicemail

Don't leave a message — just gone

67%

Call a competitor next

Immediately — no second chance

300

Missed calls/month

Average practice, all hours

61%

Staff: high burnout

UK dental professionals, BDJ study 2024

THE PROBLEM

Why the Front Desk Is Breaking

Four compounding pressure points hitting receptionists at once



The Phone Never Stops

40–60 inbound calls per day, plus a full waiting room

- During check-in, payments, or chair queries — the phone rings and **nobody can answer it**.
- Lunch, after 5:30pm, weekends: **complete dead zone**. Voicemail rate exceeds 50%.
- New patients call once. **They don't try again**. They move on.



Triage With No Training

Clinically complex decisions made by admin staff

- Receptionists must judge pain severity, urgency, and slot priority — **with no clinical qualification**.
- Getting it wrong = **patient safety risk** and potential CQC liability.
- This invisible pressure contributes directly to **emotional exhaustion and turnover**.



Burnout & High Turnover

Staff leaving faster than practices can hire

- **61% of UK dental staff** score "high" on emotional exhaustion (BDJ 2024).
- Receptionists bear rising **patient aggression** as NHS access collapses nationwide.
- Each hire takes **4–8 weeks to replace**. During that gap: phones handled badly, recalls missed, revenue lost.



Admin Overload

Far more than just answering the phone

- **CQC compliance paperwork**, NHS UDA tracking, FP17 submissions — on top of front desk duties.
- Recall and follow-up campaigns done **manually** — patients fall through the gap.
- Practice software (Dentally, SystmOne) adding complexity. **Something always gets dropped** — and it's usually the phone.

WHEN A CALL GOES UNANSWERED

What happens to that patient?

67%

Call the **next dentist** on Google immediately — no retry

78%

Hang up from voicemail **without leaving a message**

~0%

Actually wait, retry, or stick around — **almost nobody**

THE BEFORE & AFTER

Every scenario, side by side

What happens today vs. what happens with Sara

WITHOUT SARA

Busy desk, phone rings

Patient waits on hold, gives up, calls next dentist. Revenue lost silently.



Busy desk, phone rings

Sara picks up in 2 rings, handles the caller, books them in — team carries on uninterrupted.

6pm — practice closed

Phone rings, voicemail kicks in. 78% hang up. New patient gone by morning.



6pm — practice closed

Sara answers, takes booking details, confirms appointment. Morning: diary already filled.

Receptionist is off sick

Locum scrambles, phones neglected, urgent calls missed. Chaos for 1–3 days.



Receptionist is off sick

Sara keeps answering every call. Nothing falls through. No cover needed for routine calls.

Patient calls with "is my crown covered?"

Receptionist interrupts patient check-in to look it up. Queue backs up.



Patient calls with "is my crown covered?"

Sara handles FAQs instantly — hours, prices, parking, recall dates — no interruption.

Receptionist gives notice

4–8 weeks of disruption, job ads, interviews, training. Phones poorly handled throughout.



Receptionist gives notice

Sara continues without a gap. Human hire can focus on higher-value in-clinic work.

BURNOUT DATA

What UK dental staff are actually experiencing

British Dental Journal research, 2024 — dental receptionists and practice managers



"The phone was the worst part of the job. You're mid-sentence with a patient and it rings again and you know you can't get to it. You just feel like you're failing everyone at once."

— Common theme across UK dental receptionist feedback, 2024 BDJ study

THE SOLUTION

What Sara AI Does

Not a replacement — an always-on layer that catches everything the team can't reach



Answers Every Call

Every inbound call answered in 2 rings, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. No voicemail, no hold music, no missed patients.



Books Into the Diary

Sara takes caller details, checks availability, and confirms appointments directly — ready for the team in the morning.

24/7 Coverage

Live Booking



Handles FAQs Instantly

Opening hours, prices, parking, recalls, cancellations — Sara answers the routine questions without interrupting your team.

Routine Queries



Works Alongside Your Team

Sara doesn't replace the receptionist — she handles overflow and out-of-hours so your staff can focus on the patients in front of them.

Complementary



Built for UK Dental Clinics

Understands NHS and private structures, UK insurance, GDC context, and British dental practice terminology.

UK-Specific



Live in Days, Not Months

No long integrations. Sara is configured for your clinic quickly — your team doesn't need to change how they work.

Fast Setup

THE NUMBERS

Sara vs. Hiring a Receptionist

Annual cost comparison for a UK dental practice, 2026

HUMAN RECEPTIONIST

Base salary (England avg)	£26,000
Employer NI (13.8%)	£3,588
Holiday pay (5.6 weeks)	£2,804

SARA AI

Monthly subscription	£299/mo
One-off setup fee	£999
First month	FREE

Sick cover (avg 7 days)	£700
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Training & onboarding	£1,200
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Recruitment (if they leave)	£1,500
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Total annual cost	~£35,800
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NI contributions	£0
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Sick days	£0
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Recruitment	£0
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Total annual cost	~£4,587
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Annual saving with Sara

Sara works as the overflow + out-of-hours layer — not a full replacement, but even as support it pays for itself in the first month of missed calls recovered.

£31,000+
saved vs. a second hire

REVENUE RECOVERED

If Sara recovers just **10 new patient calls per month** that would otherwise be missed — at £650 average lifetime value — that's **£6,500/month** in recovered revenue against a £299/month cost. The ROI is not close.

See Sara in Action

Hear exactly what your patients hear when Sara answers the call

£299

per month

FREE

first month

£999

one-off setup

[Listen to the Live Demo →](#)

Sara AI · UK Dental Voice Receptionist · Presented by Jordan

Data sources: British Dental Journal (2024), Reach.co, Resonate AI, Oral Health Group, Open Access Government · Report generated June 2026